

## A History of Christmas in America

From VOA Learning English, I'm Caty Weaver.

Today, Steve Ember and Shirley Griffith present a special program on Christmas traditions in the United States during the first half of the 19th century.

During this period, there was no set way of celebrating the day, which was not yet an official holiday. Communities around the country honored the day in different ways. Some observed Christmas as an important Christian religious day honoring the birth of Jesus. Others celebrated the day with parties, music, drinking and eating. And, some communities did not celebrate the day at all.

But, it was during this period that Americans began to reinvent the holiday. They combined ancient Christmas traditions from different cultures with modern American influences.

Here are Steve Ember and Shirley Griffith.

In 1819, the popular American writer Washington Irving wrote a series of five essays published in a book called *The Sketchbook of Geoffrey Crayon, Gent.*

The essays describe a wealthy British landowner who invites his farm workers into his home to celebrate Christmas. The landowner recreates a traditional Christmas as it would have been celebrated in the distant past. Irving praised this looking back to ancient traditions. He liked the idea of different levels of society coming together to enjoy a festive and peaceful holiday. Washington Irving seemed to express concern about the lack of such unifying Christmas traditions in modern America.

The Christmas tree is lit during the 2024 Rockefeller Center Christmas Tree lighting ceremony in Manhattan in New York City, U.S., December 4, 2024. (REUTERS/Caitlin Ochs)

Immigrants shape Christmas traditions

Penne Restad wrote a book *Christmas in America: A History*. It shows how Americans began to slowly shape Christmas into a unifying national holiday during the first half of the 19th century. She describes how Christmas had different meanings for Americans who came from different cultural and religious backgrounds. Many immigrants brought Christmas traditions from their own countries.

Religion played a big role in how an American might celebrate the holiday. Calvinist Christians banned the celebration of Christmas. But groups such as Episcopalians and Moravians honored the day with religious services and seasonal decorations.

By mid-century, Christian groups began to ignore their religious differences over the meaning of Christmas and honored the day in special ways.

Christmas became an important time for families to celebrate at home. More and more Christian Americans also began to follow the European traditions of Christmas trees and giving gifts. Christians believed that the tree represented Jesus and was also a sign of new beginnings. German immigrants brought their tradition of putting lights, sweets and toys on the branches of evergreen trees placed in their homes.

This tradition of setting up a Christmas tree soon spread to many American homes. So did the practice of giving people presents. As these traditions increased in popularity, the modern trade and business linked to Christmas also grew.

Radio City Rockettes perform the Parade of the Wooden Soldiers dance during the Christmas Spectacular at Radio City Music Hall, Friday, Dec. 13, 2024, in New York. (AP Photo/Julia Demaree Nikhinson)

### Christmas as a holiday

As Christmas became more popular, some states declared the day a state holiday. Louisiana was the first state to make the move in 1837. By 1860, 14 other states had followed. It was not until 1870 that President Ulysses Grant made Christmas a federal holiday.

Americans already knew old Christmas songs that came from England and other areas of Europe. But many new American Christmas songs started to become popular. For example, in eighteen forty-nine, a religious leader from Massachusetts wrote the words to It Came Upon a Midnight Clear. The song Jingle Bells appeared seven years later. And, a year later, a religious leader in Williamsport, Pennsylvania wrote the song We Three Kings of Orient Are.

And of course, no discussion of Christmas would be complete without talking about one of the holiday's most famous representations, Santa Claus.

This character is based on the story of Saint Nicholas, a Christian holy person believed to have lived in the third century. Saint Nicholas became known as a protector of children. Different cultures have given him different names. These include Sinterklaas, Kris Kringle and Father Christmas. But for most Americans his most popular name would become Santa Claus.

In the 19th century, many Dutch immigrants living in the United States celebrated the feast of Saint Nicholas on December 6. Saint Nicholas was especially important to New Yorkers because of their history as a Dutch colony. In 1809, Washington Irving published his History of New York. It lists Saint Nicholas as the patron saint of New Yorkers. He describes the saint wearing a low hat, large pants, and smoking a pipe. Does this description sound familiar?

### Thomas Nast illustrations

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## Vocabulary

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society - n. กลุ่มคนโดยทั่วไปที่อาศัยอยู่ร่วมกันในชุมชนที่มีการจัดระเบียบ มีกฎหมาย ประเพณี และค่านิยมร่วมกัน

festive - adj. ร่าเริงและน่าตื่นเต้น: เหมาะสมกับการเฉลิมฉลองหรือวันหยุด

unifying - v. การทำให้ (คนหรือสิ่งต่างๆ) มารวมกันหรือเชื่อมโยงกัน

decoration - n. สิ่ง que เพิ่มเข้าไปในสิ่งอื่นเพื่อให้ดูน่าสนใจยิ่งขึ้น

practice - n. สิ่งที่ทำบ่อยครั้งหรือทำเป็นประจำ

## Reading Comprehension Quiz

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**1. What is the main subject of the special program presented by Steve Ember and Shirley Griffith?**

- A. The history of VOA Learning English broadcasts.
- B. Christmas traditions in the United States during the first half of the 19th century.
- C. Biographies of famous American writers like Washington Irving.
- D. The development of official holidays in the United States.

**2. According to Paragraph 4, what was characteristic of Christmas celebrations in the United States during the first half of the 19th century?**

- A. It was a universally recognized official national holiday.
- B. Communities across the country celebrated it in a uniform and standardized manner.
- C. There was no single established way of celebrating, with practices varying widely.
- D. It was primarily celebrated as a secular event focused on parties and drinking.

**3. What significant change regarding the Christmas holiday began to occur among Americans during the period discussed?**

- A. They started to abandon all ancient traditions.
- B. They began to officially ban the celebration of Christmas.
- C. They started to reinvent the holiday by blending old traditions with modern influences.
- D. They focused solely on adopting European Christmas customs.

**4. In what year did Washington Irving publish his series of five essays titled The Sketchbook of Geoffrey Crayon, Gent.?**

- A. 1809
- B. 1819
- C. 1837

D. 1870

**5. What aspect of Christmas did Washington Irving particularly commend in his essays, as described in Paragraph 8?**

- A. The focus on commercial trade and gift-giving.
- B. The strict observance of Christian religious services.
- C. The recreation of ancient traditions where different social classes united.
- D. The development of modern American influences on the holiday.

**6. What was Washington Irving's concern regarding Christmas in 'modern America,' according to the text?**

- A. The holiday was becoming too commercialized.
- B. There was a lack of unifying Christmas traditions.
- C. Religious groups were banning Christmas celebrations.
- D. Immigrants were changing traditional American customs too much.

**7. What is the primary focus of Penne Restad's book, Christmas in America: A History?**

- A. Documenting the official declaration of Christmas as a holiday.
- B. Analyzing the impact of commercialization on Christmas traditions.
- C. Explaining how Christmas evolved into a unifying national holiday in the first half of the 19th century.
- D. Comparing American Christmas traditions with those in Europe.

**8. How did immigrants contribute to Christmas traditions in America during the 19th century, according to Penne Restad?**

- A. They introduced the concept of banning Christmas celebrations.
- B. They established a standardized way for all Americans to celebrate.
- C. They brought diverse Christmas traditions from their home countries.
- D. They primarily focused on turning Christmas into a purely secular holiday.

**9. Which specific group of Christians mentioned in the article prohibited the celebration of Christmas?**

- A. Episcopalians
- B. Moravians
- C. Calvinists
- D. Lutherans

**10. By mid-century, what change occurred among Christian groups regarding Christmas?**

- A. They began to ban all non-religious Christmas practices.
- B. They intensified their religious differences over the holiday's meaning.
- C. They started to ignore their religious differences and honor the day in special ways.
- D. They universally adopted a single, unified method of celebration.

**11. Besides celebrating at home, what two European traditions did more and more Christian Americans begin to follow by mid-century?**

- A. Christmas caroling and elaborate feasts.
- B. Christmas trees and giving gifts.
- C. Midnight mass and fasting rituals.
- D. Public parades and street festivals.

**12. According to the text, what did Christians believe the Christmas tree symbolized?**

- A. The coming of winter and long nights.
- B. The wealth and prosperity of families.
- C. Jesus and new beginnings.
- D. The unity of different cultures.

**13. Which immigrant group is credited with bringing the tradition of decorating evergreen trees with lights, sweets, and toys to America?**

- A. Dutch immigrants
- B. British immigrants
- C. German immigrants
- D. Irish immigrants

**14. Which state was the first to declare Christmas a state holiday in the United States?**

- A. New York
- B. Pennsylvania
- C. Massachusetts
- D. Louisiana

**15. In what year did Christmas become a federal holiday in the United States?**

- A. 1837
- B. 1860
- C. 1870
- D. 1809